

Chapter 75-1

To be honest, Su Zhe's words had given Xu Qingzhu a great shock.

The instant Su Zhe appeared before her, many possibilities had flashed through her mind.

—Was he going to ask why she had been so aggressive toward Su Yao?

—Was he going to tell her to stay away from the Su family in the future?

—Or was he going to ask what exactly she knew?

But she never expected that he would ask so directly: "Do you want to acknowledge your family?"

He had already determined that she knew everything.

After all, Xu Qingzhu was still inexperienced in the ways of the world. No matter how hard she tried to pretend, she was no match for someone who had been navigating the business world for decades.

While she remained silent, Su Zhe spoke again: "She lost her memory not long after giving birth to you."

Xu Qingzhu turned her head slightly, staring at him intently, afraid of missing any subtle expression on his face.

But from beginning to end, he maintained his composure, not even bothering to lift his eyelids.

Even so, the authority he emanated made everyone in this small space unconsciously tense up.

No one could stay relaxed in such an environment.

"Do you want to know about the past?" Su Zhe asked again.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together, paused for a moment, then asked in return: "Is it cruel?"

"For you, yes." Su Zhe was blunt and had no intention of deceiving her.

After that came another long silence.

Su Zhe didn't rush her, giving Xu Qingzhu enough time to think.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu looked at him. "Why did you come to find me personally? Isn't it because you want to tell me the whole truth?"

Su Zhe shook his head. "I just came to ask for your opinion."

He turned his face to look directly at Xu Qingzhu. "If you want to acknowledge your family, then leave the Sheng family and come back. If you don't want to acknowledge them, then pretend you don't know about any of this, and don't appear in front of her again in the future."

It was obvious who "her" referred to.

This was already the best outcome Su Zhe had come up with after thinking all night.

If Xu Qingzhu frequently appeared in front of Su Yao, then Su Yao would inevitably recover her memories from back then.

Those memories were too painful for her. And if Xu Qingzhu didn't want to acknowledge Su Yao, reality would be very cruel—Su Yao would likely be unable to accept it, have a mental breakdown, and return to the state she was in many years ago.

Su Zhe didn't want to take that risk.

Of course, if Xu Qingzhu wanted to acknowledge her, that would be a different version of events.

He would clean up the mess on the Sheng family's side and do his best to help Su Yao and her daughter reunite.

After all, Su Yao's memories had already started to loosen.

"Is this a black-and-white choice?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Su Zhe nodded. "For now, yes."

"Then I—" Xu Qingzhu was about to propose a third possibility, but Su Zhe directly cut her off. "In life, you can't have it both ways. It was destined many years ago—you can only choose one. This is a deadlock."

Xu Qingzhu sat there with her head lowered in deep thought when her phone screen suddenly lit up.

It was a message from Liang Shi.

She must have been drunk, as the message even had emoticons.

【Teacher Xu, are you home ^_^】

Xu Qingzhu looked at it and smiled silently, then casually replied: 【No.】

Then she faced the pressure Su Zhe was bringing her again, but this time she inexplicably felt more confident.

"Then I need to hear about what happened over twenty years ago before I make a judgment," Xu Qingzhu said. "I hope you can recount it as objectively as possible."

Su Zhe chuckled lightly. "Are you ready?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded gently.

Chapter 75-2

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On the way home from the company, Xu Qingzhu forced herself to stay alert while driving, not daring to relax for a single moment.

Only when the car had pulled into the villa's courtyard did she turn off the engine. She slumped over the steering wheel, feeling her entire back soaked with sweat, her legs weak and limp, unable to exert any strength.

Su Zhe had tried his best to suppress his emotions while recounting those events from back then, but as he spoke, his eyes gradually reddened.

He didn't even curse her grandparents, truly doing as Xu Qingzhu had requested—recounting the events from back then as objectively as possible.

Xu Qingzhu followed his words back to twenty-three years ago.

Back to the days that had been most painful for Su Yao.

If she hadn't met Su Yao before, this story might not have carried much weight for Xu Qingzhu.

At most, her sympathy would have overflowed, and she would have commented that it was truly tragic.

But she had seen Su Yao twice.

Once was watching her silhouette from afar, and once was going up to confront her.

Though it was only her performing a one-woman show.

After all, Su Yao had lost her memory and didn't remember anything.

After hearing everything Su Zhe said, she suddenly felt regret—if only she hadn't appeared in front of Su Yao.

That way, she could have pretended she didn't know anything and continued living on her original track.

But now...

Xu Qingzhu had completely fallen into a dilemma.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi, who had been sent back to the villa by a designated driver, was currently sitting crookedly on the sofa, staring intently at her phone.

Ten minutes ago, she had sent a message to Xu Qingzhu that still hadn't received a reply.

She had asked Xu Qingzhu: 【Do you think I'm too indecisive?】

No reply!

But the previous message had been replied to instantly!

Liang Shi sat there, her whole brain fuzzy and dizzy, her head aching.

She pressed her temples, trying to relieve the pain, when she heard that familiar mechanical sound ring out in her mind.

【Ding dong! Congratulations to the Host for completing the hidden mission: Find Xu Qingzhu's biological parents!】

Liang Shi: "?"

What was it saying?

She was completely bewildered.

The System continued to announce: 【Reward received: One million yuan. Additionally, because the Host completed the mission within fifteen days, bonus reward of two hundred thousand yuan, totaling one million two hundred thousand yuan. This reward will be deposited into your account within ten minutes. Please check and confirm!】

【PS: Little Tong finds this incredible, so I checked the Host's luck attribute and discovered it's actually 3S! Is this the joy of being a lucky player?】

【Another PS: This mission also has an additional reward. If you can help Xu Qingzhu reunite with her parents, there will be an extra reward of five hundred thousand yuan. Of course, Xu Qingzhu doesn't have a father now.】

【Yet another PS: Little Tong also really wants to experience the joy of winning while lying down. Not having to do anything yourself and having someone else help complete the mission—it's just too wonderful!】

【One more PS: Congratulations to the Host for obtaining a new title: Lucky Salted Fish!】 ^1^

Liang Shi: "....."

She was dazed for a long time. It wasn't until the words "Lucky Salted Fish" appeared that Liang Shi slowly came back to her senses: "Does this title have any use?"

System: 【It's purely a title that Little Tong bestowed upon you. It has no practical use, but it can very well summarize your state during this mission! Are you satisfied?】

A chatty system was really quite unlikeable.

Especially when Liang Shi had a headache.

Liang Shi was speechless, thinking to herself—when had her life ever been associated with the words "lucky" and "salted fish"?

Both parents dead, she had always depended on her grandparents for survival. After her grandparents passed away, she couldn't afford proper schooling due to financial difficulties. While others were happily living in the cradle of family, she had already started working odd jobs everywhere to support herself.

The little luck she had was used up in meeting her grandparents and entering the entertainment industry. But unexpectedly, not long after entering the entertainment industry, before she could even struggle for many years, she was blacklisted across the entire internet because of filming a yuri drama, with her rivals paying for smear articles.

Her brief life could be quickly summarized.

How could it possibly be associated with the word "lucky"?

This system was ridiculous!

Moreover, she had always been conscientious and hardworking, so she couldn't possibly be associated with "salted fish" either.

After quickly recalling all this, she retorted to the System: "Not satisfied."

System: 【There's nothing that can be done about it. After all, you earned over a million just lying down. Little Tong is jealous and envious, ying ying ying!² Right now, Little Tong is a lemon spirit.】³

System: 【The whole world is helping you complete your missions—if this isn't called lucky, then what is?! You have a misunderstanding about your own luck attribute. It really, really is 3S level.】

"Is your understanding of luck over there different from ours?" Liang Shi asked. "Is 3S the lowest?"

System: 【.....】

The strange mechanical voice suddenly became shrill: 【It's F! F! The order is C-B-A-S-2S-3S-5S.】

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"What about your 4S?"

【4S is for car dealership service centers.】⁴

Liang Shi: "?"

Hello?⁵

Do you think you're funny?

But after that, the System just reminded her to keep working hard and complete missions properly—same as before, just repeating itself over and over.

Liang Shi forcefully exited, not wanting to listen to its useless rambling.

After she exited, she noticed that her account had an additional 1.2 million, and it slowly dawned on her—

What did the System just say?

It said she completed a hidden mission?

So... Xu Qingzhu knew about her own background now?

Knew everything?

Questions kept popping up in her mind. She almost instinctively took out her phone to call Xu Qingzhu, but when her finger slid to that number, she paused.

She got up and turned on all the lights in the house, making it very bright. Then she casually grabbed a coat from the entryway and went outside to wait for Xu Qingzhu.

But after she went outside, she discovered that Xu Qingzhu's car was already parked out there.

Footnotes:

¹ **Salted Fish (咸鱼)**: Chinese internet slang for someone who has no ambitions or motivation, just wants to lie around and do nothing—like a salted fish that's already dead and preserved. It's often used self-deprecatingly or humorously.

² **Ying ying ying (呜呜呜)**: A cutesy onomatopoeia representing whimpering or crying sounds, often used playfully online to express being pitifully sad or jealous.

³ **Lemon spirit (柠檬精)**: Chinese internet slang for someone who is extremely jealous or envious, derived from the sour taste of lemons representing the bitter feeling of jealousy.

⁴ **4S**: In China, "4S店" refers to automobile dealerships that provide four services: Sale, Spare parts, Service, and Survey. The System is making a pun, avoiding "4S" in its ranking system because it's commonly associated with car dealerships.

⁵ **Hello? (歪?)**: "歪" (wāi) is a casual/colloquial way of answering the phone in Chinese, similar to "Hello?" The literal meaning is "crooked/slanted," but it's used as phone greeting slang. Here, Liang Shi is using it rhetorically to express disbelief, like saying "Excuse me?" or "What?"

Chapter 75-3

Xu Qingzhu was slumped over the steering wheel, her back arched in a curve.

The wind blew and sobered Liang Shi up considerably. She stood in the wind, the hem of her fitted trench coat dancing wildly.

She hesitated for a moment and was about to step forward when Xu Qingzhu suddenly lifted her head.

Their eyes met across the distance. Liang Shi opened her mouth but couldn't say anything, only watching as Xu Qingzhu smiled.

Xu Qingzhu tucked her hair behind her ear, leaned back in her seat, and also smiled carelessly.

Only then did Liang Shi step forward. She opened the car door and keenly caught a scent that didn't belong to Xu Qingzhu.

It was the scent of an adult Alpha.

Liang Shi frowned but quickly smoothed her expression. She didn't ask anything, only saying to Xu Qingzhu: "Teacher Xu, welcome home."

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up and sniffed lightly. "Teacher Liang, how much did you drink?"

"Just a little," Liang Shi said. "Not much. Zhao Xuning got drunk."

"Oh~" Xu Qingzhu drew out the syllable, as if teasing.

She didn't mock her for still having Zhao Xuning call the designated driver for her.

"Alright." Liang Shi chose to skip this topic and asked her, "Have you eaten?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I had a piece of bread in the evening."

"Then come inside," Liang Shi said. "I'll cook some noodles for you."

"Can you add a poached egg?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded with certainty. "Yes."

Neither of them brought up that sensitive topic.

After returning to the villa, Liang Shi took off her trench coat and busied herself in the kitchen. She first poured herself a glass of honey water to help sober up, then turned on the gas stove to cook noodles.

The kitchen door wasn't closed. Xu Qingzhu half-reclined on the sofa, gazing at Liang Shi's back from afar.

The lights in the house were brighter than usual—stepping inside immediately felt heartwarming.

Bright tones would lift one's mood along with them. She nestled in the sofa and kept thinking about Su Zhe's words.

She finally understood why Su Zhe had said this wasn't a black-and-white choice.

Even with mental preparation, she still needed time to adapt to the truth.

She decided to go back home tomorrow if she had time. She couldn't just listen to one side of the story about the past.

Just as she was planning for tomorrow, Liang Shi called out to her: "Teacher Xu, the noodles are ready. Come eat."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu get up and walk toward the dining table. As she passed by Liang Shi, her back accidentally brushed against the back of Liang Shi's hand. Liang Shi frowned and said, "Why is your back so cold?"

Xu Qingzhu sat down in a chair and answered in a low voice, "I don't know."

"Go upstairs and change into something warmer later," Liang Shi said. "The temperature is going to drop again soon, and it'll rain tomorrow. Don't think you can ignore the weather just because you're young. Change into fleece-lined pants tomorrow, or you'll get chronic joint pain in your legs."¹

Liang Shi rambled on with her reminders, pouring out everything she could think of all at once.

Xu Qingzhu took a bite of noodles and suddenly interrupted her, "Teacher Liang, the noodles are too salty."

Liang Shi was surprised. "No, they're not?"

Xu Qingzhu picked up a chopstick full of noodles. "Try it if you don't believe me."

She said it with such certainty that Liang Shi suspiciously bent down and took a bite.

"The taste is just right," Liang Shi said. "Do you have a light palate?"

But when they had eaten together before, their tastes had been about the same.

Except that Xu Qingzhu could handle spicier food than her.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and said, "I'm not sure, but I can't finish this much."

After hearing this, Liang Shi went to the kitchen and brought out an empty bowl. She had Xu Qingzhu transfer a few chopsticks worth of noodles into it, then held the bowl and sat across from her, looking at her with a smile. "Teacher Xu, is it not as salty now?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, took another taste, and said, "It does seem less salty now."

Liang Shi: "Then eat more."

Xu Qingzhu didn't want to eat alone but also wanted quiet, so she expressed it in this strange way.

Liang Shi suddenly understood her.

Late into the night, the two of them shared a bowl of noodles. By the end, Xu Qingzhu discovered two eggs at the bottom of the bowl.

One fried egg and one poached egg.

"Why are there two?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi said, "I was too idle in the kitchen, so I made two."

Xu Qingzhu said, "I can't finish them."

Liang Shi passed the bowl over again.

Xu Qingzhu hesitated for a moment, then used her chopsticks to split both eggs in half, putting one half of each into Liang Shi's bowl.

Liang Shi: "....."

They finished the meal in relative quiet. While cleaning up, Liang Shi talked to Xu Qingzhu about the house situation, then naturally segued into gossiping about Zhao Xuning to help Xu Qingzhu shift her attention.

She didn't say anything too secretive, just mentioned that Zhao Xuning had dated her ex-girlfriend for six years and things were still unclear between them now.

Xu Qingzhu sighed with emotion. "Dr. Zhao's ex-girlfriend is indeed very charming."

"What's lost is always the best," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "What about now?"

"Now Teacher Xu is the best," Liang Shi blurted out.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu had been sitting on the sofa, hugging a pillow and spacing out, looking somewhat listless. But hearing Liang Shi's words now, she couldn't help but laugh. "Teacher Liang, exactly how much did you drink? You're still not sober?"

Liang Shi walked out of the kitchen, backlit, her hands that had just been in water gleaming white. She leaned against the doorframe with a satisfied smile. "You finally laughed."

Xu Qingzhu's smile froze for an instant, then she patted the spot beside her. "Come sit."

Liang Shi walked over and sat down, prepared to listen quietly to what she had to say.

But Xu Qingzhu said, "Let's watch a horror movie!"

Liang Shi: "....."

Was this reasonable?

Deep down, Liang Shi felt it wasn't reasonable, but seeing Xu Qingzhu's eager expression, she steeled herself and agreed.

Footnotes:

¹ **Old cold legs (老寒腿)**: A Chinese colloquial term for chronic joint pain or arthritis in the legs, typically associated with cold and damp weather. It's believed to be caused by prolonged exposure to cold, especially when young, and becomes a recurring problem in old age. Hence the warning not to dress too lightly in cold weather.

Chapter 75-4

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People who have lived alone for a long time never watch horror movies, and they also tend to refuse suspense films and novels.

Fortunately, Liang Shi wasn't curious about this genre, nor could she say she liked it.

To create the right atmosphere, Xu Qingzhu even turned off the living room lights.

Seeing that she was dressed lightly, Liang Shi got up to close the window, then went to the bedroom to fetch a blanket.

Xu Qingzhu asked her, "Aren't you going to cover yourself?"

Liang Shi shook her head expressionlessly. "I'm not cold."

"You can cover yourself when you're scared," Xu Qingzhu said. "Otherwise you'll feel like the cold is seeping into your body."

Liang Shi still shook her head. "It's fine, I'm not scared."

Only a faint light glowed from the TV. Outside, the wind howled fiercely, rustling as it blew past the window frames. From the TV came mournful, ghostly wailing, followed by the sound of high heels clicking across a marble floor.

Click-clack, click-clack—

Xu Qingzhu was already covered with the blanket, watching expressionlessly.

Liang Shi glanced at the TV, then sneaked a glance at Xu Qingzhu, thinking she couldn't be scared.

So she tried her best to avoid making any big movements.

Twenty minutes later, Liang Shi had scooted over to Xu Qingzhu's side.

Xu Qingzhu remained expressionless, watching those strange little ghosts on TV as if she were looking at stuffed dolls—completely unfazed.

Whenever Liang Shi saw those terrifying-looking little ghosts suddenly appear without warning, her heart would always skip a beat.

So she kept moving closer and closer to Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Teacher Liang, are you scared?"

Liang Shi: ".....I'm scared that you're scared."

Xu Qingzhu: "Oh~"

From that drawn-out tone, one could sense Xu Qingzhu's faint mockery.

But Liang Shi still didn't move away.

The movie on TV became more and more frightening. An empty, deserted room, with the protagonist standing alone in a room lit by an eerie green glow, where something terrifying could appear at any moment.

Every time something appeared, Liang Shi moved a little closer to Xu Qingzhu.

.....

Until suddenly, a female ghost with long hair dressed in red appeared on the TV—a sudden jumpscare right in the face.

Liang Shi directly hugged Xu Qingzhu, burying her head in the crook of her neck, catching the fresh orange scent from her hair.

Xu Qingzhu was squeezed so tight she almost couldn't breathe. She just lightly patted Liang Shi's shoulder.

Liang Shi: "Teacher Xu, you're so scared—how about we just turn it off?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She couldn't help but laugh. "Alright."

Only after the TV was turned off did Liang Shi come back to life.

She ran to the kitchen and drank an entire glass of water, then took many deep breaths. Only after calming down did she walk back out. By then, all the living room lights had been turned on, restoring its previous brightness.

Liang Shi spoke earnestly to Xu Qingzhu: "Teacher Xu, one shouldn't pursue too much excitement in life. Don't you think?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Teacher Liang's lesson is correct."

Liang Shi: "....."

She couldn't shake the feeling that Xu Qingzhu was being passive-aggressive with her.

But in this life, who doesn't have something they're afraid of?

Still, Liang Shi felt a bit guilty. Xu Qingzhu had originally been upset and probably wanted to use the horror movie to relieve her mood. But halfway through, she had been so on edge that the movie got turned off.

Liang Shi tentatively suggested, "How about we finish watching it with the lights on?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "Let's not watch it."

Liang Shi hesitated. "Are you angry?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her in bewilderment. "Huh?"

"No," Xu Qingzhu denied. "What do I have to be angry about?"

Liang Shi apologized in a low voice. "I'm sorry, I'm not used to watching these things."

"There's nothing to be sorry about." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "Pour me a glass of water. I have something to tell you."

Liang Shi had a feeling that they were only now getting to the main topic.

She didn't pour water—instead, she warmed up a glass of milk for Xu Qingzhu.

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu finally gathered her emotions. "Su Zhe came to find me."

Liang Shi was shocked. "He came to find you? To warn you?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly. "He asked if I wanted to return to the Su family."

.....

Xu Qingzhu concisely told Liang Shi what had happened over twenty years ago.

Liang Shi unconsciously touched the bracelet on her wrist.

That was given by Old Madam Sheng to Su Yao, which meant the other party had once been wholeheartedly prepared to accept this daughter-in-law.

But unexpectedly, Sheng Qinglin's death had triggered so many changes.

Chapter 75-5

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu, "What are you planning to do?"

"Go home tomorrow," Xu Qingzhu said. "I need to hear what others have to say."

"Do you need me to accompany you?" Liang Shi asked gently.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "No need. Aren't you planning to go to the orphanage tomorrow?"

"I can go another day, if you need me," Liang Shi said. "I'll accompany you."

"No need." Xu Qingzhu shook her head calmly, having already sorted out all her emotions. "Go do your thing. You can't help me with this matter."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Xu Qingzhu, do you think I'm particularly useless?" Liang Shi suddenly asked softly, with a hint of bitterness.

Xu Qingzhu was taken aback. "What are you talking about? Still not sober from the alcohol?"

"No," Liang Shi said. "I just feel like I can't help you with anything."

"How could that be?" Xu Qingzhu said. "You were the one who found out about this first. Besides, Teacher Liang, how do you think you could help me with this kind of family issue tangled up with past grievances?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"I should at least do something for you," Liang Shi said. "You look so....."

Fragile yet strong.

Xu Qingzhu blended these two qualities together very well.

It was rather heartbreaking.

She wanted to do something for her but felt powerless.

"Tonight's noodles and milk were both very good." The corners of Xu Qingzhu's lips curved up as she said warmly, "At times like this, having someone give me a steaming bowl of noodles and a cup of hot milk is the greatest help. Thank you, Teacher Liang."

As she spoke, she even bent at the waist and gave a mock bow.

Liang Shi: "....."

"Teacher Liang," Xu Qingzhu suddenly raised an eyebrow. "Are you using the alcohol as an excuse to fish for compliments?"

Liang Shi: "No! That's not it! Impossible!"

A very emphatic triple denial.

But Xu Qingzhu laughed. "Alright, understood. Teacher Liang's noodles tonight were very delicious. I ate until I was very full."

Liang Shi: "....."

For some reason, her ears felt hot listening to this.

"Oh, right." Xu Qingzhu held her milk and stood up, preparing to go upstairs. Before turning around, she patted Liang Shi's shoulder. "Teacher Liang is very decisive, has high aesthetic taste, and is very considerate of others. It was out of unconditional trust that I handed over the heavy responsibility of house-hunting entirely to Teacher Liang."

"Also, Teacher Liang is very useful," Xu Qingzhu continued. "Without Teacher Liang, how could I highlight my composure while watching horror movies?"

Liang Shi: ".....!!!"

After saying that, Xu Qingzhu went upstairs.

Liang Shi belatedly realized what had happened and suddenly smiled while watching her retreating figure.

Although she had been passive-aggressively teased, Xu Qingzhu's mood should have been adjusted by now.

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To prove that she wasn't actually that scared, before bed, Liang Shi compiled a list of horror movies and sent it to Xu Qingzhu.

She had put a lot of effort into compiling it—just from the stills and synopses, they looked extremely terrifying.

Liang Shi: 【Teacher Xu, if you can't sleep, you can watch these slowly.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....】

Liang Shi: 【If you're scared, you can call me.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....】

Liang Shi: 【If you're really, really scared, you can come watch in the living room... I can too.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【Don't know what to say.jpg】

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sent a 3-second voice message. Her voice carried a hint of amusement, her cool tone rising, lingering and melodious: "Teacher Liang, go to sleep. Good night."

Liang Shi: "....."

She listened to this voice message three times over and over, then finally tapped the screen with trembling fingers: 【Okay, Teacher Xu. Good night.】

Chapter 75-6

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The next day was sunny.

Liang Shi had arranged with Gu Zhaoyuan to go to the nursing home to deliver books to the children.

She went to a bookstore at noon and bought many age-appropriate books for children. Xu Qingzhu also had some. In the evening after work, she confirmed once more with Xu Qingzhu whether she needed Liang Shi to accompany her back to the Xu family home.

Xu Qingzhu replied: 【Really no need. I'll go straight back with my dad after I get off work.】

Liang Shi reminded her: 【Then eat first before discussing matters.】

Otherwise she wouldn't be able to eat afterward.

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....Okay, Liang Nag.】

Liang Shi:

She had already been given all sorts of strange nicknames by Xu Qingzhu.

On the way to the orphanage, Liang Shi also received a phone call from the producer of the "Mo Guang" production crew, saying they planned to start filming in another week. The opening ceremony would be held next Friday, and they asked if she could coordinate her schedule.

Liang Shi happily agreed.

The preliminary preparation work for filming here was no different from her original world, so Liang Shi could adapt quickly.

However, this also meant she needed to move quickly.

Only after moving could she join the crew with peace of mind.

Her scenes weren't particularly numerous. This was definitely a dual female lead drama, and her character was considered the third female lead.

If all her scenes were compressed together for filming, it would probably only take a little over half a month.

It would depend on how the director arranged things. They would also need to coordinate with the lead actresses' work schedules, so it might not be finished that quickly.

As for her work at Dongheng, it was probably coming to an end as well.

Firstly, she didn't have time, and secondly, it wasn't really appropriate to continue staying at Dongheng.

Liang Shi had always been pessimistic in her thinking but optimistic in her actions.

The Liang family's true daughter had caused such a big commotion and even borrowed official influence—she would probably be able to reunite with the family soon.

Once they reunited, she would be a redundant existence at both Dongheng and the Liang family.

However.....

She remembered that in the book, the original owner being driven out of the Liang family happened much later in the story.

By that time, Xu Qingzhu was already close to taking the company public and had entered a lovey-dovey ambiguous phase with the rightful Alpha.

Now that rightful Alpha hadn't even appeared yet.

Liang Shi felt that not only was she straying further and further down the path of being OOC^2^ in terms of characterization, but she was also doing just as much in terms of plot OOC.

Just as the car stopped at the entrance of the Ci'ai Nursing Home, that mechanical voice of the System sounded in her mind: 【So you do know!】

Liang Shi: "....."

"Will Lu Jiayi still appear then?" Liang Shi said. "I'm starting to have doubts."

System: 【She will, but who knows when. You haven't even been here for two months and you've already pushed this world's storyline forward quite a lot. Great job!】

Liang Shi: "....."

She couldn't shake the feeling that the System was being passive-aggressive, but she didn't have time to argue with it.

It was just an AI. No need.

Gu Zhaoyuan was already at the entrance waiting for her. The books she had brought filled the trunk and the back seat, almost stuffing her entire car full.

After organizing all the books, Liang Shi went with Gu Zhaoyuan to see the former Director Gu.

Passing through a deep, long corridor, the two stopped in front of an old vermillion wooden door. Gu Zhaoyuan knocked lightly on the door. "Dad, are you awake?"

The door slowly opened. Today, Director Gu seemed to be in quite good spirits, sitting in the room reading a book.

The lighting inside the room was fairly bright. He was holding a copy of "One Hundred Years of Solitude" in his hands.

Yet another literary classic shared between both worlds.

Liang Shi greeted him in a low voice, "Hello, Director Gu."

The old man glanced at her, his voice somewhat strange. "Who are you?"

"This is a friend who plans to help me rebuild the orphanage," Gu Zhaoyuan introduced her. "Her name is Liang Shi. She just delivered a batch of books here today. She's a very kind-hearted person."

Liang Shi simply nodded with a smile.

Upon hearing this, Director Gu's attitude toward her improved a little, though he continued reading his book. "So what do you want with this lousy old man?"

Gu Zhaoyuan brought over a chair for her, positioned right across from the old man.

Liang Shi asked in a low voice, "I came to ask you about something."

"What?"

Liang Shi hesitated for two seconds before saying, "Do you know someone named Yang Jiani? And also... Qi Xiangui, commonly called Mr. Qi."

The moment she finished speaking, Director Gu's pupils contracted slightly.

He directly tore the book in his hands in half and shouted loudly at Liang Shi, "Lunatic! Lunatic!"

Footnotes:

¹ **Mo Guang (餘光)**: The title of the drama Liang Shi will be filming. It translates to "Lingering Light" or "Afterglow"—referring to the remaining light at the edge of one's vision or the last traces of light.

² **OOC**: Stands for "Out of Character," a term commonly used in fan fiction and online literature communities. It refers to when a character behaves in ways inconsistent with their established personality or when plot events deviate significantly from the original storyline.